



AP PHOTO/GREG BAKER

EARLY BIRDS: Chinese girls practice during gymnastics training



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Sports fields 8,50,000

Stadiums 6,20,000

Sports meet (per year)

Sports schools 44,000

Students trained

Professional athletes

Coaches

National athletes

Elite international athletes

Funds allocated for Beijing team

In 2005, 30 per cent Chinese found to be sporty, per cent targeted by 2010

THE SPEND FOR PREPARING CHINA'S ATHLETES FOR BEIJING 2008 WAS \$586 MILLION. THAT MAKES IT MORE THAN \$11 MILLION FOR EVERY GOLD.

Within China, there is now a growing debate around an unrelenting sports system which has churned out its champions but also spit them away. In 2007, the case of long-distance runner Ai Dongmei who tried to sell her medals on the Internet after she struggled to find a job, caused a stir. Jiang Yi, the editor of *Sports Illustrated China* says, "Our sports academies have to reform in the future; parents are reluctant to send their children to a place that does not provide a proper education and different options."

The Chinese Government knows that sport is a quasi-diplomatic tool and the ideal non-threatening advertisement for its growing global power. After the staggering success of Beijing 2008 on all counts, what could possibly be next? The consensus in China indicates that the resources available for Beijing 2008 will taper off. Jiang says, "In the old days, sports was a way of propaganda, a way to build national pride, but today I don't think winning a gold medal

is such a big deal for people. Twenty years ago, yes, but China is a more confident country now."

People may think of sport in one way but China's monolithic government is under no compulsion to agree with its people. The final press conference of the Chinese Olympic Committee (coc) featured a row of six sober middle-aged men in suits. One of them was Sports Minister and coc President Liu Peng who, far from being triumphalistic, adopted a tone of gracious humility.

As a slack-jawed world listened, Liu said, Beijing had given the Chinese the opportunity to "learn from all of you" and emphasised the need for his countrymen to "keep sober-minded". China, he rued, was still "lagging behind" in the medal count, in the number of athletes figuring in the top 8, in track and field, swimming, cycling. The Chinese were still, he emphasised, "unbalanced" in terms of the medals they won.

After an Olympics in which they cleaned out a nice, even rounded num-

ber of 100 medals, more than half of them gold, Liu was taking understatement to a new level. Or maybe he was actually resorting to the grand euphemism so typical of this rising Middle Kingdom where riots are referred to as "mass incidents" and the punishment of public confession reclassified as "self-criticism". They even refer to their team as the "Chinese Olympic delegation" making them sound like WTO diplomats pushing for more favourable export terms and not what it really is—the formidable, athletic species now known to the world as *Olympus buttkickus*.

Hidden behind Liu's solemn introspection is, quite possibly, the beginning of the next stage in China's sporting evolution. An industrious and methodical nation has identified some new targets. Maybe at the end of the Beijing Olympics, what China really wanted to say to the sporting world gathered inside its courtyard was this: hello everyone and thanks for coming. From this day on, be afraid. Be very afraid. ■